



FIGURE 8.15 Typical black-and-white Bedouin tent.

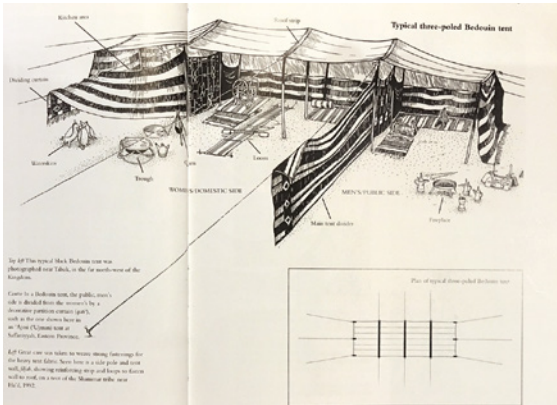


FIGURE 8.16 Typical three-poled Bedouin tent

black and white, with a little red-dyed wool for decoration. This wool comes from sheep and camels, whose wool is known for its softness and, when left undyed, for its beautiful natural colors.⁴⁹

Figure 8.16 indicates the complex nature of the interior of a Bedouin tent. The inside area is divided into many parts, each of them with its specific use. It is important to note that a “well-to-do” Bedouin tent like the one shown in figure 8.16 indicates the higher status of the family living in it than that of a family living in the humbler,

three-poled tent in figure 8.15. These images also show that different areas are used by men and by women.⁵⁰ For example, the tent contains a space which is allocated to female weavers, like a studio where they perform their craft and practice their skills.⁵¹ Thus, in the Bedouin society, the tent is a not only a signifier of social relationships and family status but also of gender roles. It is, therefore, an extremely important space because here women make items that support their family or tribe.

While the function of the textile is to create and demarcate the Bedouin space, the way the space is constructed influences the way the nomads live and the way the family or the tribe is perceived by the outside world. The textile is, therefore, structuring the formation of a private and a public identity by delineating the space: the outside, non-patterned textiles are public, while the inside, patterned textiles are private.⁵² We can infer,

50 See also Dickson, *The Arab of the Desert*, 66–67; and Canavan, “Applications of Textile Products,” 541. Here, Canavan explains that dividers were parts of women’s possessions, accompanying them into marriage, as well as “testimony of a tribe’s wealth and prestige.”

51 Refah Al Raheel, interviewed by Rana Al-Ogayyel, Riyadh, 2017.

52 While the outside of the traditional tents is black and without much pattern except for stripes, the inside of

49 For details, see Al-Sabah, *Ibjad*, 17.